

standing – of what it means to find money difficult to understand or get to grips with. I didn't know where my messy finances fitted, because there was nowhere for them to go. There was a disconnect between what I knew in theory, and the decisions that I had been making in practice, and I couldn't find anybody talking about the solution to that. As I began to unravel things further, to understand them and to process them, I realized that there's a huge part of 'finance' that doesn't belong with bank accounts and credit scores at all. It belongs in the health and wellbeing space, along with all the other ways we look after ourselves. It is part of self-care – something that I find is increasingly reduced to or conflated with personal grooming or physical fitness – and a crucial part at that. There is so much more to self-care than the superficial or trend-led elements that we read about and feel compelled to try.

Money is often ignored in conversations about broader wellbeing; we are told to 'take a mental health day', 'treat yourself to a massage' or 'try this life-changing green juice' without any consideration that, for lots of people, even a day's worth of statutory sick pay will leave them short, and that medical prescriptions and nutritious food are enough of a financial strain for many. In addition to the monetary cost, these commercial solutions to being physically or emotionally unsettled will only paper over the cracks, if the reality is that your relationship with money is well and truly broken, and you are trying to quieten a feeling that comes from deeper down.